legitimacy of the central government. In sum, China seems to be quite stable internally in the sense that system-wide disaffection against the communist party is absent.[33]

What if anything, then, could tip China over into nationwide instability? Four possibilities exist: a sustained and significant economic downturn after a long period of growth and betterment; defeat in war (or even in a big crisis); poor government handling of a natural or ecological disaster; and an increasing feeling that fundamental lifestyle preferences are unavailable to a large part of the population.

Historians and social theorists have argued that a period of economic growth followed by a period of downturn against the expectation of long-term advancement can produce widespread unrest, even revolution. Defeat in war or surrender in a crisis could also spark popular anger. A massive natural disaster that threatens millions of people by itself may not trigger revolt, but an ineffective response to it could. Climate change is one candidate for such a disaster. Huge water scarcities – always a fear in China historically – could also mobilize a revolt. A pandemic, if not controlled, has the potential to become a nationwide disaster. Covid-19 was controlled, and the vaccines promise that the end of the story will be a happy one. The next pandemic may be less tractable. Finally, comparisons with lifestyles in other countries could fan large-scale disaffection, particularly among the elite. In the USSR, the Soviet elite, led by Mikhail Gorbachev and the reformists, acknowledged that their system of governance was simply not delivering the kind of lifestyles that Western people enjoyed and that the gap was widening. Those lifestyle preferences were not just economic; they were also political and social. The spread of the social media helps publics become aware of how others live and could suddenly make the Chinese more aspirational in large numbers.

That Xi and the communist party have significantly tightened their grip on Chinese politics since 2012 suggests that in their view there are huge challenges ahead. Competition with the US is one reason for the tighter grip – Chinese society must be disciplined for the rigours of the US challenge. But surely nervousness about China's domestic stability is also a reason for